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GST 101: Use of English I - Grammar, Concord and Comprehension

A practical companion for the compulsory Use of English course every UNIZIK fresher takes

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Most freshers lose easy GST marks not because English is hard, but because they answer by ear. This pack turns the rules of concord, tense, punctuation and comprehension into short, testable patterns you can apply under exam pressure. It includes a sentence-error drill, a summary-writing method and a 7-day revision plan.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Apply subject-verb agreement rules to tricky sentences involving collective nouns, indefinite pronouns and correlative conjunctions.
- Identify and correct the ten sentence errors that recur most in Nigerian university English tests.
- Read a passage once and extract its main idea, tone and supporting details without re-reading everything.
- Write a clean summary and a short argumentative paragraph with a clear topic sentence and evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What the course is really testing

GST 101 is not a literature course and it is not a spelling bee. It tests whether you can use English as a precision instrument: can you say exactly what you mean, understand a dense passage, and spot a sentence that breaks a rule?

The paper usually mixes objective questions with short written tasks. Objective sections reward recognition - you either know the rule or you do not. Written sections reward structure. A candidate with average vocabulary and strong structure routinely beats a candidate with impressive vocabulary and no paragraph plan.

Treat the course as a small set of repeatable skills: agreement, tense consistency, pronoun reference, punctuation, register, comprehension and summary. Each one can be drilled separately.

- Agreement: the verb must match its real subject, not the nearest noun.
- Tense: reported speech and time markers must stay consistent within a sentence.
- Reference: every pronoun needs one clear noun it points to.
- Register: a formal letter and a WhatsApp message should not sound the same.

Concord: the marks hiding in plain sight

Concord questions are designed to trick your ear. Read for the subject first, ignore the phrase between the subject and the verb, then choose.

- Each, every, either, neither, everyone, somebody and nobody take a singular verb: 'Each of the students has a copy.'
- Two subjects joined by 'and' take a plural verb, unless they describe one idea: 'Bread and butter is my breakfast.'
- With 'either...or' and 'neither...nor', the verb agrees with the nearer subject: 'Neither the lecturer nor the students were ready.'
- Collective nouns take a singular verb when the group acts as one unit and a plural verb when members act separately: 'The committee has decided' versus 'The committee are divided.'
- Phrases beginning with 'a number of' take a plural verb; 'the number of' takes a singular verb.
- Uncountable nouns such as information, advice, furniture, luggage and equipment are singular: 'The information is correct.'

> **A 10-second exam habit**
> Cover the words between the subject and the verb with your finger. Read the skeleton sentence aloud in your head. If it sounds wrong with the short subject, it is wrong.

The sentence errors that cost the most marks

Examiners reuse a small family of errors because they separate students who understand grammar from students who memorise rules.

- Run-on sentences: two independent clauses joined by a comma. Fix with a full stop, semicolon or conjunction.
- Sentence fragments: a dependent clause standing alone. 'Because the lecture started late.' is not a sentence.
- Dangling modifiers: 'Having finished the assignment, the lecturer collected it.' The lecturer did not finish the assignment.
- Faulty parallelism: 'She likes reading, to swim and dancing.' Keep the list in one grammatical form.

- Pronoun ambiguity: 'Chidi told Emeka that his phone was missing.' Whose phone? Rewrite with a name.
- Double negatives: 'I did not see nobody.' Use one negative.

Comprehension without panic

Do not read the passage as if it were a novel. Read the questions first, then read for the answers.

1. Spend 45 seconds reading the questions and underlining the key word in each one.
2. Read the passage once at normal speed. Mark the paragraph that seems to contain each answer.
3. Answer in your own words where the question says 'in your own words'. Lifting the exact sentence usually earns nothing.
4. For inference questions, choose the option the passage supports, not the option that sounds generally true.
5. For tone questions, look at the writer's verbs and adjectives, not the topic alone.

> **Watch the qualifiers**
> Options containing always, never, all, only and must are usually wrong unless the passage says so directly. Options with some, often, may and tends to are safer when the passage is cautious.

Summary and short writing

A summary is not a shorter copy. It is a compressed statement of the main points in your own words, with no examples, repetition or personal opinion.

- Find the topic sentence of each paragraph. Those sentences usually carry the main points.
- Delete examples, statistics, dialogue and restatements.
- Combine related points instead of listing them mechanically.
- Keep the original order of ideas and the original tense.
- Check your word limit. Being far under the limit usually means you omitted a main point.

The sentence is an argument about relationships

Most sentence errors in student writing are not errors of grammar but errors of relationship: the subject and verb disagree about number, the pronoun has no clear owner, or the modifier attaches itself to the wrong noun. A sentence is a small claim about who did what, and every element must agree on the answer.

Start with the verb and find its subject. In "The list of items were submitted", the subject is list, not items, so the verb should be was. Long noun phrases are where agreement collapses, because the nearest noun is often not the subject. Strip the phrase down: "The list was submitted" - correct, then rebuild.

Misplaced modifiers are the second common failure. In "Having finished the experiment, the results were recorded", the results did not finish the experiment; the writer did. The dangling participle signals a hidden agent. Name the agent or restructure: "Having finished the experiment, we recorded the results."

Paragraphs that do work

A paragraph makes one claim and supports it. The topic sentence states the claim; the middle sentences supply evidence, example or explanation; the final sentence either draws the consequence or sets up the next claim. If a paragraph has two claims, split it. If it has none, delete it or fold it into a neighbour.

Cohesion is created by more than connectives. Repeat key nouns, use pronouns with clear antecedents, and order information so that the end of one sentence gives the beginning of the next something to pick up. "However", "therefore" and "moreover" do not create logic; they announce logic that must already be there.

Length is a symptom, not a rule. A paragraph of two hundred words is usually two or three paragraphs pretending to be one; a paragraph of one sentence is usually an assertion that has not been supported.

> **Vary the subject**
> If five consecutive sentences begin with the same subject, the writing will feel mechanical even if it is correct. Change the opening: a phrase, an adverb, a subordinate clause.

Punctuation as control of pace

The full stop ends a thought; the comma separates elements within it; the semicolon joins two related complete thoughts and signals that the relationship matters; the colon introduces an explanation, a list or a quotation. The dash interrupts. Each mark tells the reader how long to hold a unit of meaning.

The commonest error is the comma splice, joining two complete sentences with only a comma. "The results were inconclusive, we repeated the test." Fix it with a full stop, a semicolon, or a conjunction. The second commonest is the apostrophe: it marks possession (the student's work) or a contraction (it's = it is), never a plural. Its and it's are different words.

Read your work aloud and mark where you naturally breathe. Those are your punctuation points. A sentence with none is usually a sentence you have not yet understood well enough to control.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Repairing a bad paragraph

"Myself and my friend went to the library, we were reading for the exam and it was very useful because we learnt many things and also the library was quiet and conducive." Rebuild it.

1. Split into claims: who went, what they did, what they gained, what condition helped.
2. Fix the pronoun: "My friend and I", not "Myself and my friend".
3. Remove the comma splice by using a full stop or subordination.
4. Replace vague praise ("very useful", "many things") with specific content.
5. Cut "also the library was quiet and conducive" into a supporting clause.
6. Result: "My friend and I revised in the library for three hours. The silence let us work through two past papers together, and by the end we could explain the harder topics to each other."

> **What to carry forward**
> Specificity plus correct sentence boundaries fixes most "weak writing" in one pass.

2. Fixing agreement in a long sentence

"The committee, after considering the reports submitted by the various departments, have decided that each of the students are to be interviewed."

1. Find the main subject: committee.
2. Note that committee is singular here, taking a singular verb: has decided.
3. Find the next subject: each, which is singular: each of the students is to be interviewed.
4. Keep the interrupting phrase but check it separately: reports submitted by departments is plural and correct.
5. Re-read the sentence with the core intact: "The committee has decided that each of the students is to be interviewed".

> **What to carry forward**
> Strip the sentence to its core, check it, then rebuild. Agreement errors hide inside long phrases.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Identify and correct the errors: "Its important that every student submit there assignment before the deadline, otherwise they will loose marks."

10 marks

1. Its should be It's (it is).
2. There should be their (possession).
3. Submit is acceptable in the subjunctive after "important that", but the sentence should be consistent.
4. Loose should be lose.
5. They has an unclear antecedent - use "the student" or "students".
6. State the pattern: homophones and apostrophes account for most of these errors.

Q2. Explain the difference between a comma splice and a fused sentence, with one correction each.

10 marks

1. Comma splice: two independent clauses joined by a comma alone.
2. Fused sentence: two independent clauses with no punctuation at all.
3. Correct either with a full stop, semicolon, or conjunction.
4. Give one example of each and its repair.

Q3. Write a well-formed paragraph of 120-150 words on why academic writing avoids slang, and underline your topic sentence.

15 marks

1. Topic sentence makes one claim about audience and precision.
2. Two sentences of explanation.
3. One example of slang replaced by precise language.
4. A concluding sentence that draws the consequence.
5. Check sentence boundaries, agreement and apostrophes before submitting.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Writing about the topic without demonstrating control of the sentence.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Subject-verb agreement. The requirement that a verb matches its subject in number and person.

Comma splice. Two independent clauses joined by a comma without a conjunction.

Fused sentence. Two independent clauses written with no punctuation between them.

Dangling modifier. A modifying phrase whose intended subject is not the subject of the sentence.

Topic sentence. The sentence stating the claim a paragraph will support.

Cohesion. The linking of sentences through reference, repetition and logical order.

Semicolon. A mark joining two related independent clauses or separating complex list items.

Apostrophe. A mark showing possession or a contraction, never plurality.

Antecedent. The noun a pronoun refers back to.

Register. The level of formality appropriate to audience and purpose.

Clause. A group of words containing a subject and a verb.

Concord. Another term for grammatical agreement between sentence elements.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Sentences

Boundaries and agreement.

- Correct ten sentences from your own past work.
- Practise stripping long sentences to the core.
- Learn the four homophone pairs you confuse.

Week 2 - Paragraphs

One claim each.

- Underline the topic sentence in five paragraphs you wrote.
- Rewrite one paragraph with a single claim.
- Remove every connective that is not doing logical work.

Week 3 - Punctuation

Control of pace.

- Read an essay aloud marking breaths.
- Fix every comma splice.
- Check every apostrophe.

Week 4 - Register

Audience.

- Rewrite a chat message as a formal email.
- Identify slang in an old essay and replace it.
- Write 300 words to a specified reader.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any university Use of English course text covering sentence grammar and paragraphing.
- A punctuation guide covering the comma, semicolon and apostrophe.
- A good dictionary and thesaurus - consult the dictionary for usage, not just spelling.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Choose the correct verb: 'Neither the Dean nor the lecturers ___ available.'

Answer: were. With neither...nor, the verb agrees with the nearer subject, 'lecturers'.

2. Rewrite correctly: 'Having submitted the form, the portal closed.'

Answer: The sentence has a dangling modifier. Rewrite as: 'After I submitted the form, the portal closed.'

3. Is 'The committee are arguing among themselves' correct?

Answer: Yes. The plural verb is acceptable when members of the committee are acting individually. Use 'is' when the committee acts as one body.

4. What is wrong with 'She gave me an advice'?

Answer: 'Advice' is uncountable. Say 'a piece of advice' or 'some advice'.

5. In a summary, should you include the examples in the passage?

Answer: No. Include the main points and omit examples, repetitions and minor details.

6. Identify the error: 'The number of applicants have increased.'

Answer: 'The number of' takes a singular verb. It should be 'has increased'.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write out the seven concord rules in your own words and invent one example for each.
- [ ] Do 20 sentence-correction items from any credible English workbook and mark every error by rule name.
- [ ] Read one Guardian or Punch editorial and write its main idea in two sentences.
- [ ] Summarise a 500-word passage in 90 words without copying whole sentences.
- [ ] Write one argumentative paragraph with a topic sentence, two supporting points and a conclusion.
- [ ] Ask a friend to mark your paragraph for agreement and punctuation only.
- [ ] Re-do every question you missed after 48 hours, not immediately.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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